Diagnosing and Reframing a City Parks & Recreation Department: From Strategy–Execution Gaps and Mission Drift to Coherent, Future-Ready Practice

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PRT 506: Organizational Behavior and Leadership in Parks, Recreations, Tourism & Sport

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September 29th, 2025

Organizational Context

The Parks & Recreation Department of the City of Naples is located in a small coastal city with a resident population that, while small, wealthy, and older than average, and a service demand that varies significantly throughout the year due to the impact of tourism. Naples is home to 19,115 people according to the 2020 U.S. Census Bureau QuickFacts (U.S. Census Bureau, 2024), and its size, median age, and median income compared to national averages inform the mix of programs, facility amenities, and level of service expected by residents and accepted by government (U.S. Census Bureau, 2024). The impacts of tourism are also core to the context: Visitor profile and seasonality in Collier County drive demand increases for beaches, trails, special events, and aquatics during the winter "peak" season and the mix and use of youth programs and camp facilities during the summer shoulder season. The county tourism office provides detail about the magnitude of seasonal surges and the impact on local attractions, overnight lodging, and recreational use, which in turn drives facility and staffing loads for municipal recreation programs (Visit Naples, 2025). The department currently operates 13 city recreation facilities as of 2025, which include Arthur L. Allen Tennis Center, Baker Park, Cambier Park, Charlie C. Anthony Park, Fleischmann Park, Lowdermilk Park, Naples Dog Park, Naples Landing, Naples Preserve, Norris Community Center, River Park Aquatic Center, River Park Community Center, and The Edge Johnny Nocera Skate Park (City of Naples, 2025). The present indicators of organizational effectiveness for the department are NRPA-aligned in their focus and are typical of many NRPA standards: program participation/utilization and fill rates, costs recovered by program/class, customer satisfaction from post-program surveys, and condition/compliance of assets (timeliness of inspections, safety findings, etc.) (National Recreation and Park Association [NRPA], 2024a). These performance indicators already help to

assess efficiency (doing more with less) and effectiveness (doing the right mix of services) and will have an organic link to the dashboard anchored by mission that is proposed later in this paper (Behn, 2003; Matheus, Janssen, & Maheshwari, 2020).

In practice, the department's asset and programming mix are fairly representative of the U.S. municipal and county departments benchmarked through the National Recreation and Park Association (NRPA): multi-site indoor facilities (community centers, senior facilities), outdoor parks and courts, special event spaces, and aquatics, as well as trails, beach accesses, and programming (including youth, active adult, and special events). From the NRPA's Agency Performance Review (APR) that details the "typical" financial and operational profile of municipal parks agencies across the U.S., such a department "serves" one park per ~2,386 people, "maintains" ~10.6 acres per 1,000 people, "employs" ~57.6 FTEs, and has a median annual budget just shy of $6.5 million. The precise data here for Naples isn't the focus, but the national medians provide context for capacity, labor mix, and per-capita considerations in a small city with a high-service benchmark and seasonal volatility (National Recreation and Park Association [NRPA], 2024a).

Coastal exposure is a simple, if not existential, environmental reality for Naples. Southwest Florida is identified in NOAA and federal science-to-action syntheses of U.S. hotspots for relative sea-level rise, compound flooding, and heat stress, which have direct implications on the operation of shoreline parks, boardwalks, turf/tree management, hardscape maintenance, ADA access, and storm-resilient design guidelines. Hazard planning is "business as usual" for the coastal recreation system (assets, master planning, etc.) because they're integrated into standard asset stewardship, grant justifications, and capital prioritization processes (U.S. Global Change Research Program, 2024).

Organizationally, the department sits in a council–manager form of municipal government, with annual budget cycles tied to the city's fiscal calendar; a series of enterprise and non-enterprise funds; and policy review by elected representatives. The small size of Naples heightens the prominence of department leaders and the proximity of stakeholders. Citizens, "snowbird" homeowners, young families with children, tourism-related businesses, philanthropic partners, and neighborhoods are among the many audiences that consistently and directly articulate expectations about litter control, special event quality, fields maintenance, and user fees. Strategically, this is both an opportunity (direct accountability loop, high levels of civic pride) and a challenge (political visibility of even minor operational adjustments). Operationally, it also requires leaders to balance their premium on service quality with a discipline in strategic focus, on the one hand, and the constraints of labor markets (notably for seasonal and part-time work) and the technical aspects of recreation compliance, on the other (aquatic safety standards, playground certification, ADA compliance, procurement regulations, etc.). Sector-wide data illustrate these latter constraints: surveys by the National Recreation and Parks Association (NRPA) found departments have come to rely on part-time/seasonal employees to expand their programming, while facing ongoing recruitment and retention challenges that in turn affect the reliability of execution, particularly during peak periods. (NRPA, 2024b).

Perceived Problems

Two core but interwoven organizational problems have emerged, which are binding constraints on the department's efficiency and effectiveness. One is a strategy–execution gap: Leaders and supervisors have the ability to communicate good strategic intent (e.g., "activate parks for all ages", "raise the level of customer experience", "sustain world-class beaches and amenities"), but execution on these goals often breaks down in the last mile—uneven program fill rates,

bottlenecks in procurement or scheduling, slow work order turnarounds for fields/courts, reactive rather than proactive communications, and inconsistent application of data to course correct. The general management literature is replete with analyses of this phenomenon. Mankins and Steele (2005) show that organizations in general only deliver about 60–65% of the value promised by their strategies, and the culprits include breakdowns at handoffs, overstuffed portfolios, weak resource–priority alignment, and weak performance routines; the correspondence to recurrent municipal problems is striking when a small staff has to wear many hats and when priorities proliferate across seasons (Mankins & Steele, 2005).

The second pressure is for mission drift. Naples' taxpayers are right to demand clean facilities, signature programming, and attentive service; but the influence of seasonal visitors and philanthropists also opens the door to attractive but tangential add-ons that can gradually shift the department away from its core public mission. Seasonal use, image marketing, and contract revenues can create pull on the department's activities that nibble at its public purpose unless they are carefully controlled. Studies of "mission drift" in hybrid and nonprofit organizations describe how complex funding arrangements, multiple stakeholders, and growth pressures nudge organizations' mix of activities away from their stated purposes over time, in the absence of disciplined focus (Ebrahim, Battilana, & Mair, 2014). For city recreation, mission drift looks less like commercialization than the gradual and often quiet replacement of less visible but core investments in asset maintenance, safety, and access equity by more photogenic events, retail amenities, and targeted partnerships (Ebrahim et al., 2014).

Both are problems. A strategy–execution gap is an inefficient use of the limited seasonal capacity and a betrayal of trust when a promised upgrade or program fails to materialize. Mission drift dissipates resources, weakens equity objectives, and increases long-run operating costs by

postponing core maintenance. Seasonal demand in Naples exacerbates both risks: when the busy months arrive, any mismatch between plan and staff or any shortchanging of mission-critical work is very apparent to both residents and visitors. The cost of inaction is not just internal inefficiency but reputational and political – two currencies that do have value in a small, engaged city.

Problem Analysis Through Bolman & Deal's Four Frames

Structural Frame

At a structural level, the department exhibits textbook patterns of goals-roles-processes misalignment during peak variance months. Mintzberg's (1994) classic critique of the mechanistic over-formalism of planning rings true in the municipal sphere; plans that are "book thick but routine thin" and have less-than-obvious span-of-control, resource gating, and decision rights are poised to perform poorly when reality meets the contingencies and interruptions of the operating environment. Seasonally, with fields/courts/multipurpose rooms scheduling cross-purposes with event preparation and beach clean-up/maintenance/repair, or both, plus the unexpected, the result has become our famous unanticipated issues (Mintzberg, 1994). When roles are ambiguous, handoffs are lengthy, and procurement or work-order systems require multilevel approval, the organization slips its rhythm. A recent HBR suite on execution has emphasized the pivotal role of resource allocation in enabling delivery; absent translation of priority objectives into early, specific staff and budget decisions, and absent paring portfolio load to capacity, execution drifts into heroic firefighting (Mankins & Steele, 2005). NRPA APR's medians offer a sanity check; agencies Naples's size that are "delivering at scale" tend to staff stable cores for "always-on" functions and flex predictably with well-timed seasonal staff and specific SOPs (NRPA, 2024a). Naples's reliance on seasonal workers is not surprising. However,

there is a performance gap between what is stated and what actually happens on the ground, which can provide opportunities to simplify the process and commit resources earlier to convert plans into reliable results (Bolman & Deal, 2021).

Human Resource Frame

In the HR frame, the key is frontline capacity and latitude. Parks and rec systems succeed or fail based on the engagement and discretion of coordinators, maintenance technicians, lifeguards, instructors, and event leaders. The public-service and occupational health literatures are replete with findings that job control and supportive supervision have positive impacts on reducing burnout and increasing performance; high demand with low control predicts burnout and turnover. Reviews and meta-analyses indicate that increases in job control (decision latitude) are related to decreased emotional exhaustion and better performance, and that a supportive climate can mitigate the impact of seasonal demand (Aronsson et al., 2017; Sonnentag, 2023). In Naples, for instance, seasonal compaction of work, variable weather conditions, and frequent interactions with the public create stress. When the rules for protocol or approvals are unclear and decision making centralized, staff who feel time-pressured cannot improvise; mistakes are made and the quality of customer experience suffers. It is the HR frame that suggests potential solutions such as targeted empowerment, training in “what great looks like,” and establishing feedback loops that narrow the distance between data and action at the front line (Aronsson et al., 2017; Sonnentag, 2023) (Bolman & Deal, 2021).

Political Frame

The political frame in a small city with active civic groups and stakeholders includes a long list: full time residents; seasonal residents and part-time homeowners; neighborhood groups; youth sports leagues; donors and philanthropists; environmental groups; tourism-related businesses;

and regulatory agencies. All can rightly argue they have a say in fees and scheduling and events and capital priorities and beach policies. Without clear stakeholder mapping and coalition building, decisions end up serving the strongest voice instead of the mission. Bryson's work on strategy in public and nonprofit organizations focuses on making clear the sponsors and champions and potential blockers, aligning them through transparent processes, and convening forums that bring the tradeoffs out in the open early, before they become calcified into opposition (Bryson, 2018). A political process that doesn't draw people will cause mission drift: one-off commitments to a donor or one user group can shift programming away from the common good. Leaders in Naples must create long-lasting coalitions for "core" results – safe, clean, accessible parks, inclusive participation, and resilient coastal resources – so that budget and timeline decisions are a negotiated public value instead of ad hoc compromises (Bryson, 2018) (Bolman & Deal, 2021).

Symbolic/Cultural Frame

Symbolically, Naples's parks are civic showpieces: beaches and parks are key facets of the city's brand and identity. Culture signals (how staff greet customers, how fast a broken net is replaced, whether trails are cleared after a storm) speak louder than slogans. Kouzes and Posner write that exemplary leaders "model the way" and "enable others to act", while also investing intentional time "inspire[ing] a shared vision" (Kouzes & Posner, 2017). If middle managers are overburdened and rarely on the ground, the culture defaults to "do what you can", which hollows out the claim to "world-class" service. This is related to Collins's "right people on the bus" principle as well: greatness is constructed by "disciplined people, with a focus on disciplined systems that reinforce and sustain a day-to-day alignment of behaviors with the hedgehog concept - in this case, creating public value through equitable access, asset stewardship and

world-class customer experience" (Collins, 2001). In Naples, the symbolic work is reframing the story: what we celebrate, measure and protect is mission – safety, inclusion, stewardship – not just photo ops and festivals (Collins, 2001; Kouzes & Posner, 2017) (Bolman & Deal, 2021).

Solution & Prognosis

A Coherent Four-Part Solution

The four below interventions have a one-to-one relationship with the two diagnosed problems (strategy–execution gap and mission drift) and also cover all four of Bolman & Deal's frames for an organization (Bolman & Deal, 2021; Mankins & Steele, 2005), in order to ensure the best mix of conceptual validity and ease of use.

Strategy–Execution Fusion

Instead of dense, annual-plan binders, move to a rolling, 12-quarter “strategy-execution rhythm” in which leaders prune the portfolio, sequence work, and lock resource allocations for the next two quarters, each quarter. A one-page list of priorities, with assigned owners, service-level expectations, and a block of pre-committed staffing/overtime for the known peak season can work. Mankins and Steele are blunt in their advice: keep strategy simple and tangible, make resource commitments early, and establish a performance dialogue connecting milestones to decisions (instead of the “announce and hope” mode) (Mankins & Steele, 2005). In a city department, this means two quarterly “Resource Councils” per year, finalizing seasonal staffing levels, procurement cut-off dates, and facility maintenance windows for the known spring and winter peaks. This immediately obviates prioritization and handoff failures that result in last-mile execution delays (Mankins & Steele, 2005).

Empowered, Trained Frontline with Guardrails

Crystallize "decision rights at the point of service" for predictable cases (e.g. weather moves, minor repairs up to a certain dollar value, moves of people off program waitlists), supported by micro-training and checklists. There is evidence that greater job control and more supportive climates are associated with lower burnout risk and higher service reliability; Naples could capture these benefits by clearly documenting what employees on the front lines can decide without managerial approval and by training supervisors to give quick feedback and praise in the busy months (Aronsson et al., 2017; Sonnentag, 2023). This minimizes "high demand/low control" circumstances which foster burnout and mistakes, improving reliability where services encounter the public (Aronsson et al., 2017; Sonnentag, 2023).

Seasonal Workforce Pipeline and "Rapid Implementation Cells"

Pilot the treatment of seasonal-hire employees as part of a continuous talent pipeline, including early job offers and micro-credentials (stand-alone training modules aligned with CPRP and, where applicable, AFO/CPSI exposure) and return-bonus eligibility for high performers. Support with two cross-functional "rapid implementation cells" each peak season: small, time-boxed squads that combine maintenance, programs, communications, and procurement to clear backlogs, stage events, and compress cycle time on high-visibility items. Case studies and advisory research around public-sector agile pilots and programs show that small empowered cross-functional teams, working in concert with frequent reviews and visible product owners, can speed delivery and increase stakeholder satisfaction (Deloitte, 2020; Government Digital Service, n.d.). They help to remove multi-department queues that can otherwise slow execution when there are surges (Deloitte, 2020; Government Digital Service, n.d.).

Mission Anchors, Public Value Metrics, and a Simple Dashboard

Anchor the organization against mission drift with a pithy “mission anchor” that ties every program and project to three clusters of outcomes: (a) safe, clean, and resilient assets; (b) equitable participation and satisfaction of all demographic groups; and (c) efficient and dependable delivery. Bryson’s public-value approach links strategy to stakeholder value propositions; Behn and follow-on research on public-sector performance emphasize that measures must be fit to purposes, for example to evaluate, to control, to budget, to motivate, and to learn. Naples should pilot-light a dashboard of a small number of purpose-fit indicators of asset condition (e.g., % inspections completed on time), access/equity (e.g., participation by age/zip/income proxies), customer experience (net satisfaction), and delivery reliability (on-time work orders, program fill/cancel rates). Studies of dashboards in government show that, when designed for decisions not for display, they increase transparency and drive shifts of resources that improve both efficiency and outcomes (Behn, 2003; Matheus, Janssen, & Maheshwari, 2020). This enables budget and calendar decisions to be audited against mission, which deters drift (Behn, 2003; Matheus et al., 2020).

Risks & Mitigations

Implementation risks are procurement statutes that limit speed and agility, civil-service/union policies that hinder or dictate the redesign of roles, and "change fatigue" in a seasonal workforce. Mitigations include pre-clear rapid-buy vehicles under procurement policy, co-design changes to decision-rights with HR and labor representatives, and timing rollout through the quarterly rhythm so training and feedback cycles are predictable and not additive during peaks (Bryson, 2018; Bolman & Deal, 2021).

Evaluation & Evidence Plan

The department will measure a small number of indicators against the mission anchors in each quarterly strategy–execution review: (1) asset condition & safety (percent of inspections completed on time; corrective work-order SLA compliance rate), (2) access & equity (utilization by age/ZIP; fee-assistance redemption), (3) experience (net promoter score of post-program/park survey), and (4) delivery reliability (percent of programs started on-time; drop rate; mean time to close on maintenance requests). Benchmarks and targets will be established using NRPA medians and internal historical baselines (NRPA, 2024a), and outputs will be reported on a one-page dashboard used to shift resources on a quarterly basis (Behn, 2003; Matheus et al., 2020).

Why This Will Work

We think the prognosis for this package is strong because it directly addresses the two root problems. The strategy–execution rhythm and rapid implementation cells close the planning–delivery gap by clarifying priorities and shortening feedback loops. Empowered decision rights and micro-training to the rescue reduce burnout and release frontline problem solving right where Naples connects with its residents and visitors. Mission anchors and public-value metrics rein in the portfolio and direct scarce capacity toward what the public values most (safe, accessible, resilient parks and programs) and keep them from wandering off into second-order activities. This is in line with Kouzes & Posner's call to model the way and enable others to act, Collins' disciplined culture, and Mintzberg's insistence that strategy really is discovered in the doing and the learning and not just written plans (Collins, 2001; Kouzes & Posner, 2017; Mintzberg, 1994).

Operationally, these victories should be evident within two seasons: 1) decreased last minute cancellations; 2) faster problem-solving regarding maintenance issues (courts, fields, beach

facilities); 3) more cohesive messaging to the public; 4) and, hopefully, an increase in retention and return to season rate of staff. Over an 18–24 month period, the dashboard will enable leaders to shift funding toward the channels that demonstrably lead to access, satisfaction, and asset stewardship, while eliminating those that soak up attention but don't move the mission forward.

Prospecting the Future (3–5 Years)

Examining Naples 5-years out, several trends are converging that will favor a focused approach. On the demographic side, the city is small by resident count and an outlier by skewing older and richer than most of the country (U.S. Census Bureau, 2024). The net of that combination is an elevated appetite for quality passive outdoor recreation, health and wellness activities, low-impact sport, and shady pedestrian-friendly access. Load profiles will be seasonally affected and given Collier's overall tourism dynamics, winter peaks will persist and will demand purposeful off-season groundwork with 'staff-on' periods to scale services (Visit Naples, 2025).

On the environmental front, risks will be exacerbated along the coast. The U.S. Global Change Research Program (2024) has identified Southwest Florida as a relative sea-level-rise hotspot, with major implications for beach erosion, boardwalk and ADA walkway vulnerability, stormwater runoff in trails and campsites, and heat exposure for employees and visitors. In Naples, this means that resilience measures have to be hardwired into capital plans (i.e., materials, elevations and drainage) and advance recovery playbooks to respond before, during, and after storm events, along with aggressive tree canopy and shade measures to ensure that outdoor amenities can be used as extreme heat days become more frequent. Such investments will not be discretionary. They are what is needed to protect the fundamental promise of service

and lower the life-cycle costs of facilities and equipment (U.S. Global Change Research Program, 2024).

Labor will stay tight. NRPA data shows agencies across the country continue to use part time and seasonal labor at high levels and cite difficulty in hiring. Municipalities that focus on professionalizing their seasonal pipelines (early offers, alumni pools, micro-credentialing, return bonuses) are in a better position to maintain quality during peaks. Naples's proposed year-round pipeline and empowerment model should, in theory, drive higher return rates and build a flywheel of experience that compounds across seasons (NRPA, 2024b).

Technologically and managerially, public-sector organizations have advanced from one-shot, static reporting to decision-oriented analytics. The most successful dashboards are ruthlessly simple, tied to decisions leaders actually make, and used in regular forums that reallocate resources. If Naples sticks with a small, stable suite of public-value indicators (asset condition, access/equity, experience, reliability) and uses quarterly strategy–execution reviews to course-correct, the city can expect to see demonstrable gains in per-capita service efficiency and stakeholder trust over the next planning horizon. The performance-management literature warns of "dashboard theater" but demonstrates that purpose-fit measures, embedded in actual decisions, do improve outcomes (Behn, 2003; Matheus et al., 2020).

Politics will always matter, of course. Naples's leaders will want to institutionalize coalition routines that outlive any one leader—standing stakeholder forums with clear agendas tied to the mission anchors and the dashboard. Doing so keeps donors, neighborhood groups, program partners, and advocates aligned to the same North Star, which reduces the risk of mission drift as new opportunities arise.

Conclusion

City of Naples Parks & Recreation excels at many aspects of its work, but has long been stymied by two fundamental system-level issues: difficulty executing against strategy and an ongoing gravitational pull toward mission drift. These factors limit the organization's efficiency and effectiveness at times when the City needs it to perform at its best. A brief analysis through the lens of Bolman & Deal's frames (Bolman & Deal, 2021) revealed a clear set of actionable levers: "slice and dice" the organization's structure and processes to closely align to a rolling strategy–execution cadence; amplify and empower the frontline through clarified decision rights; rapidly deploy cross-functional SWAT teams to absorb seasonal surges; and foster alignment and accountability with a simple public-value scorecard to prevent drift. Grounded in industry data and proven management and leadership principles, this intervention package is directly tailored to the City's operating context of seasonal surges, coastal risks, and stakeholder ecosystem. The forecast is good: in 1–2 seasons, the community and visitors should have more reliable programs and services, and employees should feel healthier and more empowered in their work environment. Over a 3–5 year horizon, Naples can sustain its proud civic brand of beautiful, accessible parks and world-class beaches—while running a more disciplined, equitable, and resilient operation.

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